

## Greece

 One of Europe's oldest nations, Greece gained independence from almost 500 years of Turkish rule in 1830. Although it is the poorest member of the European Union, the country has a thriving tourist industry and a large shipping fleet. The Greek people have a strong national unity, based on their deep-rooted Orthodox religion, and a language that has remained in use for 2,700 years.



### Food

The Greeks love to eat outdoors in the warm summer months. Meals are simple and tasty and consist mainly of tomatoes, salad, olives, feta cheese, lamb, some fish, and yoghurt made from sheep's milk. Retsina, a wine flavoured with pine resin, is often served with food.



### Farming

High mountains and poor soils make farming difficult in Greece. However, agriculture employs about 23 per cent of the work-force, mainly on small, traditional farms. The main crops are olives, citrus fruits, salad vegetables, tomatoes, and grapes. Small herds of sheep and goats produce meat, and milk for cheese and yoghurt. Greece is the world's third largest producer of olive oil.

## GREECE FACTS

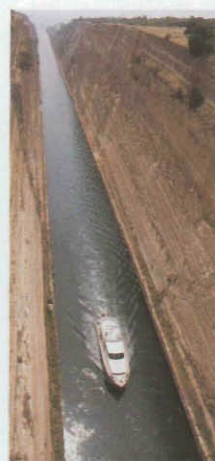
|                   |                                 |
|-------------------|---------------------------------|
| CAPITAL CITY      | Athens                          |
| AREA              | 131,990 sq km (50,961 sq miles) |
| POPULATION        | 10,600,000                      |
| DENSITY           | 81 per sq km (210 per sq mile)  |
| MAIN LANGUAGE     | Greek                           |
| MAJOR RELIGION    | Christian                       |
| CURRENCY          | Euro                            |
| LIFE EXPECTANCY   | 78 years                        |
| PEOPLE PER DOCTOR | 250                             |
| GOVERNMENT        | Multi-party democracy           |
| ADULT LITERACY    | 97%                             |

## Athens

Home to almost one-third of the Greek population, Athens is famous for its ancient buildings, such as the Acropolis and the 2,400-year-old ruins of the Parthenon temple. On certain days, cars are banned from the capital to protect the ruins. Nearby, pinewoods and mountains provide a retreat from the busy city.



Ruins of the Parthenon temple



### Tourism

Each year, more than 12,000,000 tourists visit Greece, attracted by its warm climate, ancient monuments, and beautiful islands. Tourism is the mainstay of the economy and employs thousands of Greeks each summer.

Greek islander selling sponges to tourists

### Shipping

Greece has the world's largest merchant fleet, and relies on ships to move goods between the many islands. The narrow Corinth Canal, built in 1893, links the Ionian and Aegean seas, providing important access to Athens.

## Bulgaria

 From 1944 to 1989, Bulgaria was part of the Russian communist bloc. Since gaining independence, Bulgaria is slowly adapting to a democratic government and a western-style economy. About 85 per cent of Bulgaria's population are Bulgars, with minorities of Turks, Macedonians, and Roma. The small groups have suffered discrimination, but are gaining power in parliament.

### Tourism

Bulgaria's Black Sea coast is becoming increasingly popular as a holiday destination, in particular the towns of Varna and Burgas. New airports serve western tourists, whilst Russians cross the Black Sea by ferry. Many new resorts have been built, and the natural beauty of the coastline, with its sandy beaches, pine forests, and old fishing villages, is often spoiled by high-rise hotel developments.



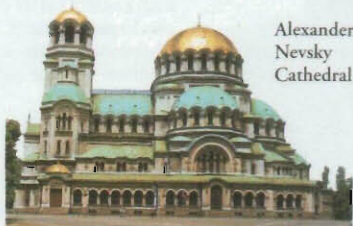
Resort near Varna

## BULGARIA FACTS

|                   |                                 |
|-------------------|---------------------------------|
| CAPITAL CITY      | Sofia                           |
| AREA              | 110,910 sq km (42,822 sq miles) |
| POPULATION        | 8,200,000                       |
| DENSITY           | 74 per sq km (192 per sq mile)  |
| MAIN LANGUAGE     | Bulgarian                       |
| MAJOR RELIGIONS   | Christian, Muslim               |
| CURRENCY          | Lev                             |
| LIFE EXPECTANCY   | 72 years                        |
| PEOPLE PER DOCTOR | 286                             |
| GOVERNMENT        | Multi-party democracy           |
| ADULT LITERACY    | 98%                             |

## Sofia

Bulgaria's capital is also its largest city, with more than one million inhabitants. Founded by the Romans, it is now the cultural and economic centre, with one-fifth of the country's industry. The Alexander Nevsky Cathedral was built in the 1870s to celebrate liberation from Turkish rule.



Alexander Nevsky Cathedral



### Energy

Twenty-five per cent of Bulgaria's electricity comes from the Kozloduy nuclear power station built by the former Soviet Union in an earthquake zone. Increased safety measures have been introduced since 1990. Bulgaria imports 70 per cent of its energy due to poor coal and oil resources, and has built a hydroelectric generator.

### Farming

Near the town of Kazanluk in the Balkan Mountains, vast fields of roses are grown. The petals, picked at dawn in midsummer, are used to produce attar, the essential oil of roses, which is used in perfume manufacture. Farther south, in the Maritsa valley, tobacco plants are grown and dried for cigarettes. Black grapes grown on the Danubian Plain are used for making high-quality red wine.

